that put avoidable pressure on the committee and ascribes it as perhaps the chief reason for the committee having acted in haste. He admits that to an outsider, it would look ‘fickle and surprising’ that he issued such an ultimatum.

Under pressure to recommend a candidate, the committee rushed to meet Mistry on 5 September 2011. It was an elaborate interaction in which it asked him thirty-two questions, ranging from his opinion on the Tatas (as a group) to his vision for 2021, including whether he would recommend divesting from companies that yielded low returns.

At the end of the meeting, the committee decided that Mistry could be considered to be recommended for the post. Its formal recommendation was, however, kept pending to informally ascertain Ratan’s views on him. The committee decided to meet again in October.

Meanwhile, the members met with Ratan who recalled that he was briefed that during the selection committee meetings, Mistry had been very active and asked ‘all the right questions’. They also apprised him that during the interactions, Mistry had expressed his desire to be considered as a candidate. However, they stopped short of saying that they had found Mistry to be the most suitable candidate. They did not want to make it appear as if they had taken a decision and had only come to seek an endorsement from their chairman.

Ratan says that he preferred not to give his opinion in the matter. He had already clarified that he wanted the board to give its considered and uninfluenced opinion. The committee members came away with the impression that Ratan was open to the appointment of any candidate they would choose to recommend after determining that he or she was the best they could get, given the time constraint, commented Krishna Kumar.

The committee met as scheduled on 17 and 18 October. On the first day of the two-day deliberations itself, the issue of succession was settled. It was a detailed interaction in which four members of the committee decided to formally recommend Mistry’s name as the sixth chairman of Tata Sons. The meeting’s minutes say: ‘CM [Cyrus Mistry] should be considered for succession to Mr RNT.’ The meeting on the following day was only a formality.

On 23 November, the committee communicated its recommendation to Ratan. Its letter read: ‘He [Mistry] has grown his own construction business domestically and internationally since his return to India. He was